

POL SCI 335: Comparative Political Systems

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Office Hours: Tue 1:30–3:30 PM & by appt

Class Time: TR 11:30 AM-12:45 PM

Room: Bolton Hall B60

[Course Website](#)

Course Description

How do political institutions shape democratic governance? Why do some countries have two dominant parties while others have many? What makes some democracies more stable than others? This course provides a systematic introduction to comparative political institutions, examining how different countries organize power, make decisions, and represent citizens.

We will analyze political systems through a comparative lens, focusing on institutional design and its consequences. Rather than memorizing facts about individual countries, you'll learn to think critically about how institutions work, why they vary, and what effects they produce. Topics include electoral systems, party systems, executive-legislative relations, federalism, judicial review, central banks, and contemporary challenges to democracy.

This course emphasizes analytical thinking and comparative reasoning. You'll develop the ability to identify patterns across political systems, evaluate institutional trade-offs, and construct evidence-based arguments about political outcomes.

Prerequisites

There is no official pre-requisite course except for junior standing. However, it would help significantly if students are familiar with materials that are normally covered in either POL SCI 103 (Introduction to Political Science) or POL SCI 104 (Introduction to American Government and Politics).

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this course, successful students will be able to:

1. Analyze how key political institutions (electoral systems, party systems, legislatures, executives, courts) function across different democratic systems

2. Compare and contrast the Westminster (majoritarian) and Consensus models of democracy, evaluating their respective strengths, weaknesses, and contexts
3. Explain causal relationships between institutional design and political outcomes (e.g., how electoral rules affect party systems; how federal structures affect economic coordination; how executive–legislative relations shape foreign policy decisions)
4. Apply comparative frameworks to analyze real-world political events and policy choices, including economic governance and foreign policy decisions, in different countries
5. Evaluate institutional trade-offs and reform proposals using evidence and theoretical reasoning
6. Assess how domestic political institutions constrain and enable both economic policy and foreign policy choices in democratic systems
7. Synthesize information from multiple sources to produce an original, evidence-based analysis of a country's political system
8. Communicate complex political analysis clearly and persuasively in written form

Required Materials

Textbook (Required)

Lijphart, Arend (2012). *Patterns of Democracy: Government Forms and Performance in Thirty-Six Countries*. 2nd ed. New Haven: Yale University Press.

- Available as free e-book through UWM Library: [UWM Library Book Link](#)
- Physical copies available for purchase if preferred

Supplemental Materials

Additional readings (articles, book chapters, policy briefs) will be provided via Canvas. These are mandatory unless marked “optional.”

The following list of books are recommended for the final project:

- Dahl, Shapiro, & Cheibub. 2003. *The Democracy Sourcebook*.
- Rhodes, Binder, & Rockman. 2006. *Oxford Handbook of Political Institutions*.
- Held. 2006. *Models of Democracy*.
- Shepsle. 2010. *Analyzing Politics*.
- Clark, Golder, & Golder. 2017. *Principles of Comparative Politics*.

Course Structure and Time Commitment

This is a 3-credit course over a 15-week semester. To succeed, plan to dedicate approximately 8–10 hours per week to this course:

- Class attendance: 3 hours/week
- Reading and studying: 4–5 hours/week
- Assignments (essays, project): 2–3 hours/week (varies by week)

Class Format: This course meets twice weekly (Tuesday/Thursday at 11:30 AM) for lectures, discussions, and activities. Tuesdays typically focus on core concepts and theory; Thursdays feature application, discussion, and student presentations. Active participation is expected.

Canvas: I will post lecture slides, study guides, readings, and assignments on Canvas. Check regularly for updates and announcements.

Assignments and Grading

Grade Distribution

Component	Weight
Participation and Attendance	15%
Country Presentations	10%
Quizzes	20%
In-Class Essays (2 essays)	20%
Midterm Exam	15%
Country Analysis Project	20%
Total	100%

Letter Grade Scale

Numerical Average	Letter Grade
94–100	A
90–93	A–
87–89	B+
84–86	B
80–83	B–
77–79	C+
74–76	C
70–73	C–
67–69	D+
64–66	D
60–63	D–
Below 60	F

Attendance and Participation (15%)

This is an in-person course, and **attendance is mandatory**. Your learning in this course depends on active, consistent engagement with class discussions and in-class activities. You are expected to attend every session and arrive on time.

If you must miss class, **notify the instructor in advance whenever possible**. Absences do not excuse you from course responsibilities. You are responsible for obtaining notes, completing readings, and submitting any required work.

Make-ups: In-class work (quizzes, participation activities, etc.) generally cannot be made up unless the absence is excused due to exceptional circumstances (e.g., illness, family emergency). Please communicate as early as possible so we can determine an appropriate accommodation when warranted.

Country Presentations (10%)

Purpose: These short presentations apply course concepts to real institutional cases. They develop comparative reasoning skills and allow us to examine specific countries in depth.

Format:

- You will present **once** in a group of 3–4 students (8 groups total)
- **10-12 minutes**
- Presentations are on **Thursdays**

Requirements. Upload to Canvas by **11:59 PM Wednesday** before your presentation:

- Slides containing:
 1. One institutional feature (using Lijphart/course concepts)
 2. One mechanism (how it affects outcomes)
 3. One comparative contrast (“compared to what?”)
 4. One discussion question for the class

Presentation Schedule:

Week	Date	Topic	Country Options
2	Thu Feb 5	Westminster Model	UK, New Zealand, Australia
3	Thu Feb 12	Consensus Model	Switzerland, Belgium, Netherlands
5	Thu Feb 26	Electoral Systems I	Spain, Netherlands, Sweden
6	Thu Mar 5	Electoral Systems II	Germany, Ireland, Japan
7	Thu Mar 12	Executive–Legislative	France, Finland, Austria
11	Thu Apr 9	Judicial Review	Germany, Canada, India
12	Thu Apr 16	Federalism & Econ Gov	Brazil, Australia, Switzerland
13	Thu Apr 23	Foreign Policy	Student choice (with approval)

Grading Rubric (10 points):

Criterion	0	1	2
Accuracy	Major errors	Minor issues	Correct
Lijphart framework	Not used	Mentioned	Applied well
Comparative insight	Descriptive only	Some comparison	Clear contrast
Clarity & timing	Disorganized or overtime	Mostly clear	Polished, on time
Discussion question	None or off-topic	Adequate	Engaging

Missed presentations: Unexcused absences on your presentation day result in a zero. Documented emergencies will be accommodated; contact me immediately.

Quizzes (20% total)

Purpose: To ensure you’re keeping up with readings and understanding key concepts.

Format:

- 4 quizzes throughout the semester
- Each quiz covers material from the previous 2–4 weeks
- 15–20 questions per quiz (multiple choice, true/false, short answer)

- Administered in class on **Tuesdays**
- 20 minutes to complete
- Open notes but closed book

Grading: Each quiz is worth 5% of your final grade.

Quiz Schedule:

Quiz	Date	Covers
Quiz 1	Tue Feb 10	Weeks 1–3 (Intro, Westminster, Consensus)
Quiz 2	Tue Mar 3	Weeks 4–6 (Party Systems, Electoral Systems)
Quiz 3	Tue Apr 7	Weeks 7–8, 10 (Exec-Leg, Legislatures)
Quiz 4	Tue May 5	Weeks 11–15 (Courts, Fed, FP, Performance)

No make-ups except for documented emergencies. Contact me before the quiz if possible.

In-Class Essays (20% total)

Purpose: To assess your ability to construct a clear comparative argument under time constraints, using course concepts and evidence. It will also help you with the midterm and the project.

Format:

- **2 in-class essays** during the semester (10% each)
- **50 minutes** in class
- **Length: 2-3 pages** (handwritten)

What a strong in-class essay does:

- States a clear thesis in the first paragraph
- Explains one causal mechanism (institution → outcome)
- Makes an explicit comparison (“compared to what?”)
- Uses concrete evidence (readings, class examples, or country cases)
- Addresses one counterargument briefly

Essay Schedule:

Essay	Date	Topics
Essay 1	Tue Mar 10	Westminster vs. Consensus, electoral systems, party systems
Essay 2	Tue Apr 21	Foreign policy institutions, economic governance

Make-ups: No make-ups except for documented emergencies. Contact me as soon as possible.

Midterm Exam (15%)

Purpose: To assess your understanding of course concepts from the first half of the semester.

Format:

- In-class exam: **Thursday, March 19** (Week 8)
- Mix of short answer and essay questions
- Covers material from Weeks 1–7

Study guide will be provided one week before the exam.

Country Analysis Project (20% total)

Purpose: To conduct an in-depth analysis of one country's political system using Lijphart's framework. You will collect institutional data, locate your country on the conceptual map, and evaluate how well its democratic institutions serve its people. Throughout the semester, there will be two opportunities of submitting in-progress work and receiving feedbacks. A more specific instruction will be provided at Canvas.

Requirements:

- Select one country
- Analyze its political institutions using Lijphart's 10 characteristics
- Final paper: 7-8 pages (double-spaced, 12pt font)
- Present your country analysis
- Sources: Lijphart is your primary source; include 4–6 additional scholarly sources for context

Course Policies**Attendance Policy**

See 'Attendance and Participation' above for the full attendance policy.

Late Work Policy

All assignments are due on the assigned date. I do not accept late assignments. If an emergency occurs, email me as soon as possible; documentation may be required and extensions are granted on a case-by-case.

Communication is essential.

Academic Integrity

Academic honesty is fundamental to the university community. Any form of academic dishonesty—including cheating, fabrication, plagiarism, or facilitating academic dishonesty—will not be tolerated.

According to UWS Chapter 14, examples of academic misconduct include, but are not limited to: cheating on an examination; collaborating with others in work to be presented, contrary to the stated rules of the course; submitting a paper or assignment as one's own work when a part or all of the paper or assignment is the work of another; submitting a paper or assignment that contains ideas or research of others without appropriately identifying the sources of those ideas; stealing examinations or course materials; submitting, if contrary to the rules of a course, work previously presented in another course; tampering with the laboratory experiment or computer program of another student; knowingly and intentionally assisting another student in any of the above.

What counts as plagiarism:

- Copying text from any source without quotation marks and citation
- Paraphrasing ideas without citation
- Submitting work written by someone else (human or AI)
- Recycling your own work from other classes without permission
- Sharing or receiving quiz/exam answers

Consequences: Academic misconduct will result in a zero on the assignment and may result in failure of the course and referral to the Dean of Students Office.

UWM Policy: uwm.edu/deanofstudents/conduct/academic-misconduct

Religious Beliefs Accommodation

On occasion, students may find it necessary to miss class in order to observe a religious holiday. In order to ensure reasonable accommodation, students should inform the instructor of the conflict beforehand. Any conflicts with assignments, tests, or other coursework must be addressed before the due date.

For more information, see: uwm.edu/Dept/SecU/acad+admin_policies/S1.5.htm

Military Duty

Students called up for active military duty should contact the instructor for accommodation.

For more information, see: uwm.edu/military-call-up-policy

Incompletes

A grade of Incomplete is reserved for exceptional circumstances where a student who has completed the majority of coursework cannot finish due to circumstances beyond their control.

For more information, see: uwm.edu/Dept/SecU/acad+admin_policies/S31.pdf

Discriminatory Conduct

For information on definitions of discrimination, harassment, abuse of power, and the reporting requirements of discriminatory conduct, see: uwm.edu/Dept/SecU/acad+admin_policies/S47.pdf

Generative AI Policy

The use of Generative Artificial Intelligence (AI) is not allowed in this class. Generative AI used to assist in assignment completion in part (e.g., generating ideas, brainstorming, summarizing information) or in whole (e.g., submitting direct text from a Generative AI source) will be considered Academic Misconduct as defined by UWS Chapter 14. According to section UWS 14.03(2):

“Examples of academic misconduct include, but are not limited to: cheating on an examination; collaborating with others in work to be presented, contrary to the stated rules of the course; submitting a paper or assignment as one’s own work when a part or all of the paper or assignment is the work of another; submitting a paper or assignment that contains ideas or research of others without appropriately identifying the sources of those ideas; stealing examinations or course materials; submitting, if contrary to the rules of a course, work previously presented in another course; tampering with the laboratory experiment or computer program of another student; knowingly and intentionally assisting another student in any of the above, including assistance in an arrangement whereby any work, classroom performance, examination or other activity is submitted or performed by a person other than the student under whose name the work is submitted or performed.”

If you are uncertain whether you are using an online learning support platform or Generative AI appropriately for this class, please discuss this directly with me before submitting coursework. All assignments that use any external source must be credited using a proper citation. Please see the resource on using and citing Generative AI provided by UWM Libraries or talk with me directly for assistance.

Email Policy

I aim to respond to emails within 24 hours on weekdays, 48 hours on weekends.

- Use your UWM email account

- Include “POL SCI 335” in the subject line
- Use professional language and tone
- Check the syllabus and Canvas before emailing

Accessibility and Accommodations

At the beginning of the semester, students with disabilities who need special accommodations should notify the instructor by presenting a letter prepared by the Accessibility Resource Center (ARC). To ensure that the most appropriate accommodations are provided, students should contact the ARC.

1. Register with the Accessibility Resource Center (ARC): Mitchell Hall 112, archelp@uwm.edu, 414-229-6287, uwm.edu/arc
2. Contact me as soon as possible (ideally within the first two weeks) to discuss accommodations

All accommodations are handled confidentially.

For more information, see: uwm.edu/Dept/DSAD/SAC/SACltr.pdf

Student Support Resources

Academic Support:

- Writing Center: uwm.edu/writing-center
- Library Research Help: uwm.edu/libraries
- Tutoring Services: uwm.edu/center-for-excellence

Wellness and Mental Health:

- Norris Health Center Counseling: 414-229-4716
- Crisis Services: Call 414-229-4716 or text “UWM” to 741741
- Dean of Students Office: uwm.edu/deanofstudents

If you’re struggling—academically, personally, or otherwise—please reach out.

Class Schedule

Note: This is a tentative schedule. Specific reading assignments will be confirmed on Canvas. All readings should be completed BEFORE the class session for which they are listed. The schedule is subject to modification—any changes will be announced in class and on Canvas.

Week 1: Introduction to Comparative Politics

Tue Jan 27: What is comparative politics? Course overview.

Thu Jan 29: The comparative method.

Readings:

- Lijphart, Chapter 1: Introduction

Week 2: Models of Democracy I

Tue Feb 3: The Westminster model; majoritarian democracy in practice.

Thu Feb 5: Group 1 Presentation — Westminster Model

Readings:

- Lijphart, Chapter 2: The Westminster Model of Democracy
- Additional reading TBD (on Canvas)

Week 3: Models of Democracy II

Tue Feb 10: Quiz 1 + The Consensus model.

Thu Feb 12: Group 2 Presentation — Consensus Model

Readings:

- Lijphart, Chapter 3: The Consensus Model of Democracy
- Additional reading TBD (on Canvas)

Week 4: Party Systems

Tue Feb 17: Two-party vs. multiparty systems; effective number of parties. Due: Project Part 1

Thu Feb 19: Party system dynamics.

Readings:

- Lijphart, Chapter 4: Thirty-Six Democracies
- Lijphart, Chapter 5: Party Systems

Week 5: Electoral Systems I

Tue Feb 24: Majoritarian vs. proportional representation; electoral formulas.

Thu Feb 26: Group 3 Presentation — Electoral Systems I

Readings:

- Lijphart, Chapter 8: Electoral Systems
- Additional reading TBD (on Canvas)

Week 6: Electoral Systems II and Interest Groups

Tue Mar 3: Quiz 2 + Disproportionality; electoral thresholds.

Thu Mar 5: Group 4 Presentation — Electoral Systems II

Readings:

- Lijphart, Chapter 8 (continued): Disproportionality and Electoral Thresholds
- Lijphart, Chapter 9: Interest Groups
- Additional reading TBD (on Canvas)

Week 7: Executive-Legislative Relations I

Tue Mar 10: In-Class Essay 1

Thu Mar 12: Group 5 Presentation — Executive-Legislative Relations

Readings:

- Lijphart, Chapter 6: Cabinets
- Lijphart, Chapter 7: Executive-Legislative Relations
- Additional reading TBD (on Canvas)

Week 8: Executive-Legislative Relations II

Tue Mar 17: Cabinet formation; government duration; executive dominance.

Thu Mar 19: MIDTERM EXAM

Readings:

- Lijphart, Chapters 6–7 (continued)
- Additional reading TBD (on Canvas)

Week 9: SPRING BREAK — NO CLASS

Mar 22–29

Week 10: Legislative Institutions

Tue Mar 31: Bicameralism; legislative strength. Due: Project Part 2

Thu Apr 2: Parliamentary procedures.

Readings:

- Lijphart, Chapter 11: Parliaments and Congresses
- Additional reading TBD (on Canvas)

Week 11: Constitutions and Judicial Review

Tue Apr 7: Quiz 3 + Constitutional rigidity; judiciary.

Thu Apr 9: Group 6 Presentation — Judicial Review

Readings:

- Lijphart, Chapter 12: Constitutions and Judicial Review
- Additional reading TBD (on Canvas)

Week 12: Federalism and Economic Governance

Tue Apr 14: Federal vs. unitary systems; fiscal federalism; central bank independence.

Thu Apr 16: Group 7 Presentation — Federalism & Econ Governance

Readings:

- Lijphart, Chapter 10: Federalism
- Lijphart, Chapter 13: Central Banks
- Rodden (2004), "Comparative Federalism and Decentralization"
- Additional reading TBD (on Canvas)

Week 13: Democratic Institutions and Foreign Policy

Tue Apr 21: In-Class Essay 2

Thu Apr 23: Group 8 Presentation — Foreign Policy

Readings:

- Lijphart, Chapter 14: Two-Dimensional Conceptual Map
- Putnam (1988), "Diplomacy and Domestic Politics: The Logic of Two-Level Games"
- Bruce Bueno de Mesquita and Alastair Smith (2012), "Domestic Explanations of International Relations"

Week 14: Democratic Performance and Quality

Tue Apr 28: Institutions and outcomes. Measuring democratic quality.

Thu Apr 30: Project Presentations Begin

Readings:

- Lijphart, Chapter 15: Macroeconomic Management and Control of Violence
- Lijphart, Chapter 16: Quality of Democracy
- Additional reading TBD

Week 15: Contemporary Challenges to Democracy

Tue May 5: Quiz 4 + Democratic backsliding; populism.

Thu May 7: Project Presentations Conclude ; Course conclusion.

Readings:

- Lijphart, Chapter 17: Conclusions
- Additional readings on contemporary challenges (on Canvas)

Finals Week: NO FINAL EXAM

Due Fri May 15: Project Part 3 — Final Paper

*This syllabus is subject to change with reasonable notice via Canvas and in-class announcements.
Students are responsible for staying informed of any updates.*